



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 39

PENNSYLVANIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Pennsylvania's family courts and child-welfare system.

90

PENNSYLVANIA FAMILIES ON RECORD
· 139 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 26
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 2, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

36 OF 67

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

PENNSYLVANIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 90 Pennsylvania families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 139 90 of 90 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,500 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 26 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 57.8% 34.4% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 90	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 90 of 90	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 36

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Pennsylvania families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF PENNSYLVANIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	58	\$15,500	\$48,921	\$2,837,440
Lost Wages	43	\$20,000	\$77,448	\$3,330,278
Other Court Fees	34	\$50	\$2,774	\$94,320
Therapy / Evaluations	41	\$2,000	\$4,275	\$175,257
Reunification Services	36	\$0	\$1,988	\$71,550
GAL Fees	35	\$0	\$2,302	\$80,570
Asset Loss ¹	38	\$27,500	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$65,050	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$27,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		26	2.2 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		2,079	173.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · PENNSYLVANIA

Most families documenting in Pennsylvania are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		42	47%
Not provided		28	31%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		9	10%
Case closed: within last 2 years		9	10%
Active case: progress being made		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		45	50%
Family Court Only		25	28%
Unknown		15	17%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		5	6%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		21	23%
3 – 5 years		17	19%
5 – 10 years		15	17%
Over 10 years		9	10%
6 months – 1 year		6	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		27	30%
Visitation Only		17	19%
50/50 Joint		16	18%
Children in Foster Care		9	10%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Erie		5	6%
Philadelphia		4	4%
Allegheny		3	3%
Montgomery		3	3%
Chester		3	3%
Lebanon		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		23	26%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		16	18%
Other: (Short answer)		15	17%
High Conflict Divorce		5	6%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		4	4%

05 PARENT VOICES — PENNSYLVANIA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Pennsylvania comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



It has ripped my son away from me and his whole family. I am a healthcare professional and have no abuse or drug history. I have custody of my other 2 children. This judge has been stripping my rights using false accusations and twisting the narrative ruling biay w my ex who has [...]

— JACQUELYN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Illegally took my children kept stalking harassing me and degrading, false reports , my son was abused twice in foster care also with no charges , alienation , lots of discrepancies and violation of due process and a lot more

— PENNSYLVANIA PARENT · SAMANTHA

MORE VOICES FROM PENNSYLVANIA

This system destroyed both children's childhood! It caused PTSD and Anxiety in the children. It ruined trusting adults and people in power positions meant to protect them (OCY, GAL) Mentally and physically ruined my health as I am currently on SSI due to being medically disabled [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my babies with no due process after being sexually assaulted by partner altercation did not happen in front of kids. Investigation of find, no imminent danger presented.

— KRYSTAL

Children lost years with rebar father due to multiple false reports of sexual abuse, trauma from unnecessary physical exams and interviews. Trauma from alienation. Children now believe they are survivors of sexual abuse that never happened. PTSD for father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has destroyed me as a person as well as making bond with my kids very hard

— ROBERT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Took advantage of my kids' mom's trauma and manipulated them into destroying our family while giving them the illusion. They are winning

— SALVATORE

Father SA'd both daughters. System has caused loss of wages though missed work, allowed for continued abuse of daughters physically, sexually, and emotionally by Father. Perpetuated post-separation and financial abuse. Judge stopped previously ordered sexual trauma eval ordered [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my children from me. Broke my heart everyday by not having them with me. Torn me and my children apart. The system has torn my children apart.

— ISABELLA

It has falsely accused, committed perjury over and over, all acknowledged by judge, false police reports.

— NICHOLAS

CYS took my grandchildren unlawfully. We are all stressed and some Depressed and need help.

— MARILYN

Completely destroyed my family and continues to manipulate the minds of my children

— JUSTIN

Destroyed a happy family. We were waiting for a date to adopt these kids.

— JULIA

Ripped is apart and did not take steps to reunify us as much as I met my goals they never intended to give my children back

— VICTORIA

Ripped away my 4 babies and handed them over to the child abuser/molester. Then blamed me for reacting inappropriately! Extreme fear for me and my side of the family. Could not say anything... or we would be placed in jail.

— LISA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have categorized my legal prescriptions as illegal drug use, removed my kids 4 times and allowed the father's to obtain sole everything with no evidence, hearing, or petition filed

— BRIANNE

They literally ripped my heart and soul right out of my body and left me with nothing inside but sheer emptiness

.....

— STACY

They killed me. To take a mother's children is to take her life.

— KRISTINA

Destroyed us they have ruined my life and my kids I can only imagine how they feel we didn't deserve this they want my children to forget that our three month old baby existed like I guess nobody's allowed to bring her up to them. They took them to the funeral without our [...]

— SAMANTHA

The system let my abuser who traumatized my kids cause chaos and strife in my life and my kids' lives. I have videos of them sobbing because he tortured them emotionally. The court protected him for being an abuser and broke my bones in front of my kids and still made them go [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I was a present father, who the corrupt system erased.

— NICHOLAS

All of the actors in our case worked together, included our court appointed lawyers. They knew what they were doing. We did not. Our family was torn apart, ripped apart and fed to the wolves of this agency with no help from anyone who knew the law. Lawyers outside of the court [...]

— MELISSA

This system has separated a healthy loving mother and her sons, ignored credible abuse, perpetuated abuse and allowed authority to be used as a weapon instead of protection. It has caused ongoing trauma, stripped the boys of their voices, and turned the pursuit of justice into a [...]

— LINDA

Has absolutely destroyed our peace and broken our family into pieces. Anyone who hears of this can't believe it happened to us!

— KAYLA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Broke it up, caused PTSD, ruined my kids future

— DOMINIQUE

Destroyed our family, our home. What was once safe and sacred now gone.

— SARAH

I have watched it destroy both me and my children's lives. It eve pushed one of my children to attempted suicide.

— CHRIS

Destruction created and will never be ok. My daughters childhood ruined

— MELANIE

The corrupt family court system doesn't care about what's best for our children they only care about their profits . They ruined our loving family tore us apart without due process or evidence of any wrongdoing.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We were legally strapped into a 10 year battle after a caseworker false testimony and even when the transcripts revealed the truth, the court refused to correct the errors.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I did what I was told by the court and quickly got my kids back

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The immense damage being inflicted upon a child through injustice is EVIL.

— MICHELE

My daughter & I still have PTSD from this experience. I couldn't afford the lawyer who wanted to sue the school and CPS for civil rights violations. The damage is permanent.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Torn my family apart and has damaged my poor son

— TAYLOR

Time is a thief and when you're robbed even of that thief, I don't even know how to explain it. I'm infuriated and disgusted.

— SAMANTHA

A crooked judge removed my parental rights and placed my son with his father who voluntarily abandoned him from the ages of 3-7 after a criminal investigation was opened on the father. The judge had police kick in my door and sent me to prison twice for trying to protect my son.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Through illegal tactics ,false allegations and due process violations Ive lost the 2 things that made this life worth fighting for. Memories, connections and trust are gone now. My heart has been cut into a million pieces, with each piece scattered around the universe with no [...]

— ANGELA

The system took my son, my dignity, and my voice. They manipulated a narrative that was unfounded despite working with every agency possible for interventions for my son instead.

— AMBER

the corruption of the cys system has done nothing short of traumatizing my daughter, myself, and my brother who lives with us. we have no other family anymore, all i want to do is teach my baby girl everything and just grow with her. almost 3 years of lost time that can never be [...]

— ASHLYN

I have my son back. My son's father/his parents attorney was found guilty of multiple things and lost her license to practice. The grandmother tried to do this again. After I already had sole custody. He was ripped from me that time for approx 3 weeks. She lied to the police I [...]

— HEIDI

58 Pennsylvania parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — PENNSYLVANIA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Pennsylvania families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

It has ripped my son away from me and his whole family. I am a healthcare professional and have no abuse or drug history. I have custody of my other 2 children. This judge has been stripping my rights using false accusations and twisting the narrative ruling biay w my ex who has a record

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Illegally took my children kept stalking harassing me and degrading, false reports , my son was abused twice in foster care also with no charges , alienation , lots of discrepancies and violation of due process and a lot more

— SAMANTHA

This system destroyed both children's childhood! It caused PTSD and Anxiety in the children. It ruined trusting adults and people in power positions meant to protect them (OCY, GAL) Mentally and physically ruined my health as I am currently on SSI due to being medically disabled with chronic pain. Narcissistic emotional abuse took a toll On my health as well as all of the physical, psychological, and emotional wellbeing of my children which all led to the last crt ordered counselors advising EMDR therapy for the trauma they experienced in their childhood. Once toxic father went no contact, children started their healing journey! It's all documented by crt ordered psychiatrist discharging daughter within 2 months and removing my daughter from her depression and anxiety meds!!!! Science doesn't lie!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— SALVATORE

Father SA'd both daughters. System has caused loss of wages though missed work, allowed for continued abuse of daughters physically, sexually, and emotionally by Father. Perpetuated post-separation and financial abuse. Judge stopped previously ordered sexual trauma eval ordered by hearing officer after testimony from children's counselor and visit supervisor regarding concerning behaviors in Father's presence, Judge cut trial time in half and witness list by much more, judge did not do forensic interviews, CPS failed to investigate and Father refused cooperation with investigation, police failed to collect evidence of SA, judge asked for evidence ahead of trial, judge did not allow closing arguments, Judge hastened order due to staff needing to leave trial early for family events. Judges have held mother in contempt without valid evidence, refuse to hold Father in contempt when evidence is court-documented.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my children from me. Broke my heart everyday by not having them with me. Torn me and my children apart. The system has torn my children apart.

— ISABELLA

It has falsely accused, committed perjury over and over, all acknowledged by judge, false police reports.

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Destroyed us they have ruined my life and my kids I can only imagine how they feel we didn't deserve this they want my children to forget that our three month old baby existed like I guess nobody's allowed to bring her up to them. They took them to the funeral without our permission. They took them at 8 o'clock in the morning before we were there that day and didn't tell us they were taking them. I was furious when I found that out.

— SAMANTHA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system let my abuser who traumatized my kids cause chaos and strife in my life and my kids' lives. I have videos of them sobbing because he tortured them emotionally. The court protected him for being an abuser and broke my bones in front of my kids and still made them go with him.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I was a present father, who the corrupt system erased.

— NICHOLAS

All of the actors in our case worked together, included our court appointed lawyers. They knew what they were doing. We did not. Our family was torn apart, ripped apart and fed to the wolves of this agency with no help from anyone who knew the law. Lawyers outside of the court system wouldn't to fight with us because they refused to go against cps. As a family unit, and separately, we were falsely accused, beaten down, gaslit and condemned. But... We have survived and our family will one day be revived.

— MELISSA

This system has separated a healthy loving mother and her sons, ignored credible abuse, perpetuated abuse and allowed authority to be used as a weapon instead of protection. It has caused ongoing trauma, stripped the boys of their voices, and turned the pursuit of justice into a source of harm for our family.

— LINDA

Has absolutely destroyed our peace and broken our family into pieces. Anyone who hears of this can't believe it happened to us!

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— ASHLYN

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I have my son back. My son's father/his parents attorney was found guilty of multiple things and lost her license to practice. The grandmother tried to do this again. After I already had sole custody. He was ripped from me that time for approx 3 weeks. She lied to the police I was thrown in jail. She attempted to 302 me and I was released but arrested right after. Zero trace of those charges but the mug shot I have in my phone and the list. He is special needs. I have him now and the fear always remains

— HEIDI

The system refuse to protect my 11-year-old denying him a PFA from a known criminal/monster and instead of helping me protect my son they helped protect my family's abuser all for financial gain

— BREANNE

The system tried to break me and has physically, mentally and emotionally hurt my children. I stood with my head held high and fought to help my children understand and work through the trauma that the system caused. As a mother that has been through it don't stop fighting for yourself and your children

— CHRISTINA

The system has shattered an already broken; but still united, family. After losing my two-year-old we were strong enough to conquer any storm; now, our whole family is in a whirlwind; confused, lost and defeated and shown zero mercy or regard to our possibly irreparable bond.

— AMBER

Family Division cancelled my 4 generational family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has made me move from my home and live in my car.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It tore us apart. It created a rift in the family dynamic and parental bond that will be forever scar my children and deprive them from the safety and comfort that they had before the system was involved.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has caused severe trauma to my son and myself. Trauma they claim to be protecting my child from. They are the ones who have caused the trauma, ripping my son from my arms.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

To not have the truth seen and all ignored has been torture to our grandchild and the whole family

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

total destruction of the family bonds, heritage, total absorption of the family wealth PAST, PRESENT, AND FUTURE wealth too! theft of one's very own sustenance.

— ALLEN

The father of my children utilizes the system for revenge and to fracture my healthy relationship with my children. He's a wicked individual and he will be held accountable. 

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took a happy thriving child and allowed a stranger with past abuse allegations and chronic alcohol problems to gain 50/50 custody all while turning this happy child into an angry child and distant kid I never met before.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have destroyed my relationship with my daughter. Many false allegations that no one investigated. Criminal case kept no possession of evidence. I'm disabled and the stress and PTSD was incredible to bare. Couldn't even get my medical needs from my house. House was destroyed the 4 years I was not permitted on the premises along with damaged and missing property.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It is completely destroyed us. We have nothing left to give. We have given everything including things. We didn't have to just do what they wanted, to be their image of a perfect parent looks like all to be told that it didn't matter what we did it was never gonna be good enough.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has torn apart my family. I was my son's safe haven as a stay at home mom and his world is shattered by the courts decisions to keep him away and be so ignorant to what's in front of their faces

— LISA

A CYS worker forced me to sign a safety plan, threatened that if I failed to sign my daughter would go in foster care. This was a first violation and she did not reveal my rights in the policy which I learned after the plan was signed and after I missed a hearing to appeal. She did not provide me with a copy of the document I signed at the time and this led to missing hearing

— MELANIE

I moved to a different county with permission of the court, a year later I lost custody of my son the judge that allowed me to move said I had no business moving, accused of alienating my son from his father, accused of so much more, I even spent the weekend in the county jail for contempt that I didn't do! I'm not sure if there is enough room for everything! I can tell you we had the biggest custody in the county! I had no chance in hell all of his relatives worked in the court house! I would file it would disappear! I had proof I filed didn't matter! I lost all contact but a phone call once a week on Fridays

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It took a beautiful, safe, loving family and turned us into an anxiety riddled broken mess who barely has the will to live. My daughter is cutting herself and I am barely hanging on. It has almost made me turn to substances but I can't and won't fail us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The family court has taken our peace and sense of safety. Everything I do must be scrutinized to avoid retaliation and unlawful loss of custody of my child. My child is neglected in the other home. I have lost faith in my fellow man and have no faith in marriage anymore. .

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

58 full approved Pennsylvania comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Pennsylvania report comes from Pennsylvania respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Pennsylvania — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 90 Pennsylvania families reporting here are not the universe of Pennsylvania families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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